unopposed after the May election'.7 'For us,' Honecker rather dishonestly explained, 'a result of 65 per cent would have been a great success. Of course, our opponents would have said so-andso many are against [us).' Moreover, he insisted falsification of polls was 'something I consider as frightful'.8 No election was perfect, he contended, but insisted the vote 'was nevertheless, by and large, correct and gave expression to the will of the people'.9

Interestingly, Günter Schabowski later insisted the election deception was not ordered by Honecker, who, he said, had confidence in the loyalty of the Party. 'Without his knowledge, the mayors were told that the Party wanted certain results. It was not done at the polls but in the mayors' offices, but the examiners of the opposition parties did their work perfectly; they had counted votes at the polls and spotted the great difference.'10

Although everyday life went on, the sham elections marked a turning point in public attitudes. Many people were no longer intimidated by threats and state violence. Almost daily, the FRG press, in particular, Die Zeit and Bild, published story after story about moral legitimacy and fiddled elections. At the same time, protestors in the GDR mobilised on the 7th of every month calling for 'free elections instead of fake numbers'. On one occasion, a protest march on Alexanderplatz in East Berlin was broken up by a massive police detachment, while in Leipzig, demonstrators displayed a remarkable degree of quiet discipline. Typically, despite calls for change, Honecker took a cautious stand, and the discontent was left to fester.

Meanwhile, Egon Krenz's image – already tarnished after the sham election – was further muddied when he congratulated Chinese authorities for their tough treatment of demonstrators in Tiananmen Square, where tanks were deployed against unarmed democracy protestors.11 His decision to applaud the brutality – intended as a warning to those in the GDR calling for reforms – only intensified resentment among the public, earning him the moniker, 'Krenz Xiaoping', a name scrawled on placards at an anti-China demonstration on 9 June in East Berlin. During the demo, protestors were arrested, interrogated and fined. Shortly after, a march on the fringes of a church congress in Leipzig saw activists show solidarity with Chinese students. Later in the month, the Church of the Redeemer in East Berlin